

are the ones who want to emulate somebody they idolise.

"For example, we have a kid now who plays with a one-hander only because he wants to become like Federer," Balachandran added.

Out of step with the times

At this juncture, players with the shot have had no choice but to make adjustments to remain competitive.

France's Diane Parry, for instance, currently the highest-ranked woman in this category at No. 30, uses both hands while returning to serve as an effective countermeasure.

Federer switched from a 90-square-inch to a 97-square-inch racket towards the end of his career. The move gave him greater power, particularly on his backhand, and helped him win his final three Grand Slam titles over just two years.

At the junior level, 16-year-old ambidextrous player Teodor Davidov has brought to the fore something that has rarely been seen, or even contemplated, in tennis. The teenager doesn't use a backhand — instead plays forehand on both sides.

Davidov's technique is special because it gives him an unusual advantage: the forehand is generally considered a more effective shot than the backhand; and he has two of them.

As for Bopanna, although the changes he made to his game were small, he said they had a positive impact on his performances.

"I made it more compact. Against the speed of the modern game, you can't always have a big backswing and expect to have enough time.

"I also became much better at using different backhands rather than thinking only about the topspin one-hander. The short backswing became a huge weapon for me, particularly in doubles.

"I could change the pace and direction, keep the ball low and use it to come forward," Bopanna explained.

Thiem also offered advice to players who have followed his path.

"I think the most important thing is to be able to take the ball early and not give up too much court position.

The return is also extremely important."

"At the same time, the one-handed backhand gives you a lot of variety, so using the slice and changing rhythm can still be a big advantage," he added.

Survival through adaptation

So, an ultimate question presents itself: What does the future hold for one of tennis' most iconic shots? Will it disappear one day?

Bopanna certainly doesn't think so. "I think the demands of the modern game naturally favour the two-handed backhand, particularly at a young age. Will the one-hander get rarer? Probably.

"But I don't think it will completely disappear. Tennis keeps evolving,

and special players will always find ways of making different styles work.

"That's also something we should protect in tennis. We don't want every player to look and play exactly the same.

"For me, the one-handed backhand will always have a place in the game. It just has to keep evolving with the game," Bopanna said.

The one-hander may no longer be tennis' default language, but it survives as one of its rarest dialects, sustained by the romance and memories on which the sport is built.

Last stand: Stefanos Tsitsipas carried the shot into the modern era, blending elegance and aggression with sublime ease.

